

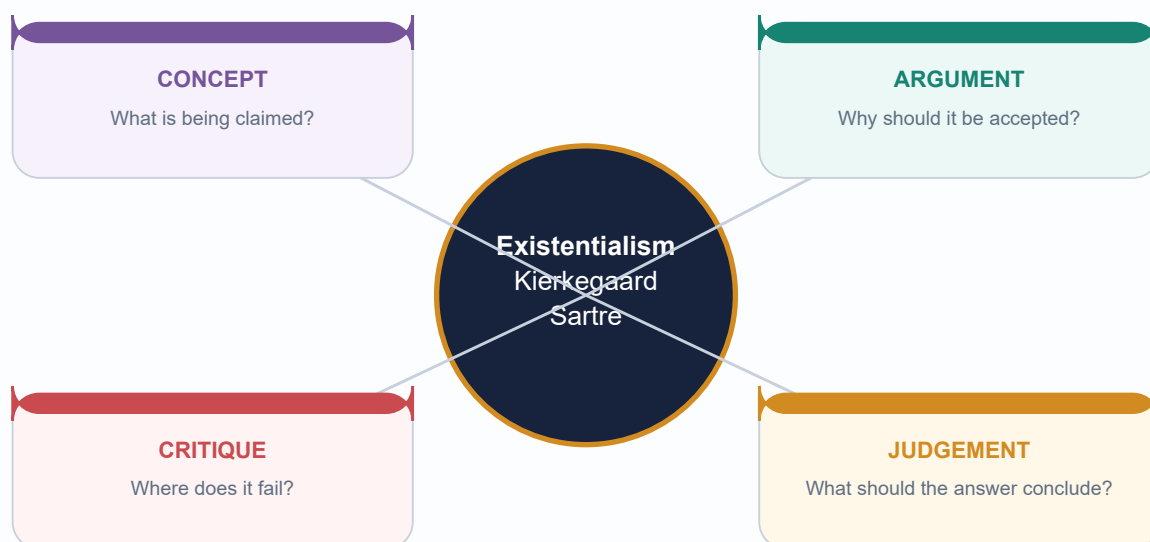
UPSC PHILOSOPHY OPTIONAL

# Existentialism — Kierkegaard, Sartre and Heidegger — Complete Visual Notes

UPSC Philosophy Optional • Paper I • Western Philosophy

Syllabus: Existence and Essence; Choice, Responsibility and Authentic Existence; Being-in-the-world and Temporality.

Direct local-book analysis • Verified knowledge cross-check • PYQ-mapped answer writing



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

## HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

## Master Map, Context and Technical Vocabulary

Paper I Western  
Philosophy

## INTRO &amp; ORIGIN

Existential philosophies place concrete, finite existence before abstract system: Kierkegaard stresses inward commitment, Sartre radical freedom, and Heidegger the temporal structure of Dasein.

*Direct local reading: Warburton, PDF pp. 284–296 and 372–407; Kenny vol. 4, PDF pp. 100–108; Cambridge Dictionary entries on Kierkegaard, Sartre and Heidegger.*

## TIMELINE

**1843** — Kierkegaard's Either/Or stages aesthetic and ethical life

**1927** — Heidegger's Being and Time analyses Dasein

**1943** — Sartre's Being and Nothingness develops freedom and bad faith

**1946** — Existentialism is a Humanism defends responsibility

## WHOLE-TOPIC DOCTRINE MAP

## EXISTENTIALISM — KIERKEGAARD, SARTRE AND HEIDEGGER

|                                                                      |                                                                      |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Kierkegaard</b><br>Subjectivity, stages and leap of faith         | <b>Sartre</b><br>Existence precedes essence; freedom and bad faith   |
| <b>Heidegger</b><br>Dasein, care, being-toward-death and temporality | <b>Shared concern</b><br>Authentic appropriation of finite existence |

## KEY DATA

| Term                       | Precise Meaning                                   | Answer Use                            |
|----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Existence precedes essence | Human beings become what they make through action | Explain the artisan analogy           |
| Bad faith                  | Self-deception that flees freedom                 | Use waiter or role example carefully  |
| Dasein                     | Being for whom its own Being is at issue          | Not simply a synonym for person       |
| Being-in-the-world         | Primordial practical involvement                  | Reject Cartesian subject/object split |
| Temporality                | Ecstatic unity of future, having-been and present | Explain future primacy                |

## STATIC THEORY

- **Syllabus coverage:** Existence and Essence; Choice, Responsibility and Authentic Existence; Being-in-the-world and Temporality.
- **Intellectual context:** Existential philosophies place concrete, finite existence before abstract system: Kierkegaard stresses inward commitment, Sartre radical freedom, and Heidegger the temporal structure of Dasein.
- **Source discipline:** claims were reconciled with the verified topic note, recent PYQs and the directly read local books listed below.
- **Theme cross-check:** substance, a priori knowledge and critiques of metaphysics were checked where relevant.

**MEMORY HOOK**

Three F's: Kierkegaard—Faith; Sartre—Freedom; Heidegger—Finitude.

**MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. Define each technical term before evaluating it.
2. Reconstruct the internal argument, not merely the conclusion.
3. Distinguish the thinker's own doctrine from a later label or criticism.
4. Use comparisons only after identifying the shared philosophical problem.

**UPSC TRAPS**

**WRONG:** All existentialists are atheists.

**CORRECT:** Kierkegaard is theistic; Heidegger's project is ontological.

**WRONG:** Existence precedes essence denies all human facticity.

**CORRECT:** Sartre distinguishes situation/facticity from self-defining transcendence.

**WRONG:** Being-in-the-world means spatial location.

**CORRECT:** It names constitutive practical involvement.

**CROSS-SYLLABUS CONCEPT LINKS**

| Core Concept    | Linked Topic           | Why It Matters                                    |
|-----------------|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Absolute system | Hegel                  | Kierkegaard protects the existing individual      |
| Intentionality  | Husserl                | Phenomenological method is transformed            |
| Cogito          | Descartes              | Embodied world-involvement replaces isolated mind |
| Faith           | Philosophy of Religion | Leap and commitment recur in reason–faith debates |

**MAINS ANGLE**

*Open with the problem that generates the doctrine; end by judging its explanatory gain against its strongest internal cost.*

**STUDY LINK**

Direct local reading: Warburton, PDF pp. 284–296 and 372–407; Kenny vol. 4, PDF pp. 100–108; Cambridge Dictionary entries on Kierkegaard, Sartre and Heidegger.

**HIGH****1. EXISTENCE PRECEDES ESSENCE**

Paper I Western  
Philosophy

**INTRO & ORIGIN**

The core reversal: for a manufactured thing (a paper-knife) the essence (its design/function) precedes its existence — the maker conceives it first. Traditional metaphysics (and theism) treated man the same way: a divine artisan makes us to a plan. Sartre denies this: "man first exists, encounters himself, surges up in the world — and defines himself..."

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## 1. EXISTENCE PRECEDES ESSENCE — ARGUMENT / OBJECTION TREE



### STATIC THEORY

- The core reversal: for a manufactured thing (a paper-knife) the essence (its design/function) precedes its existence — the maker conceives it first. Traditional metaphysics (and theism) treated man the same way: a divine artisan makes us to a plan. Sartre denies this: "man first exists, encounters himself, surges up in the world — and defines himself afterwards."
- Consequence: there is no fixed human nature, no blueprint. "Man is nothing else but what he makes of himself." We are not determined by essence, God, or biology; we are a project, self-created through action.
- Kierkegaard's version: truth is not an objective system (attack on Hegel) but "subjectivity" — what I passionately appropriate and live; existence is a task, not a spectacle.
- Heidegger's version: "the essence of Dasein lies in its existence" — human being is not a what (a fixed nature) but a how, a being for whom its own being is at issue.

### MEMORY HOOK

**Three F's: Kierkegaard—Faith; Sartre—Freedom; Heidegger—Finitude.**

### MUST-KNOW FACTS

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**MAINS ANGLE**

Reconstruct this section as a sequence of premises and consequences, then test the precise inferential bridge challenged by critics.

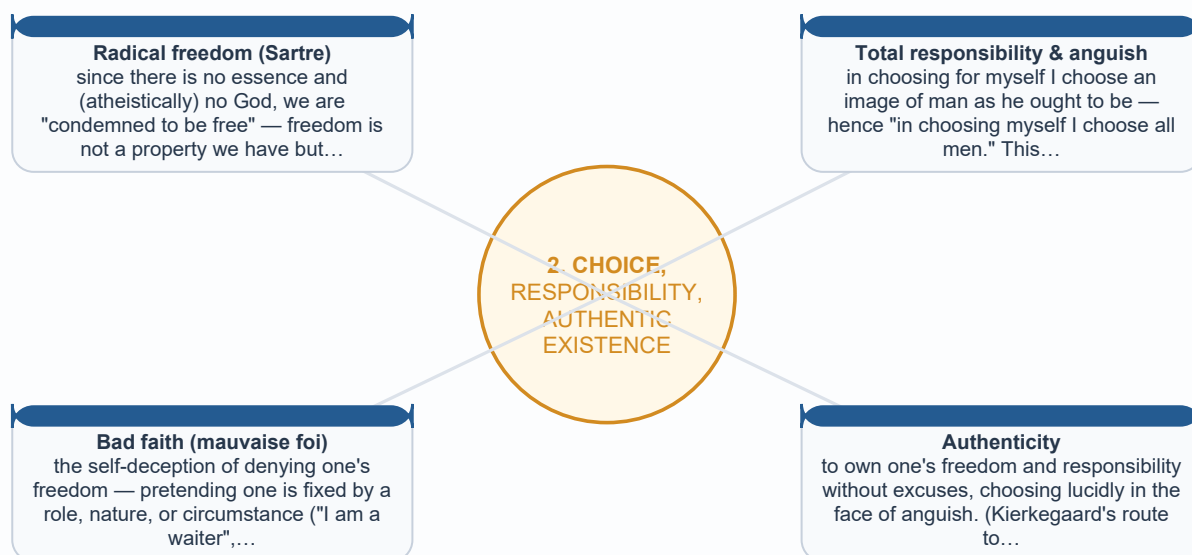
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**HIGH****2. CHOICE, RESPONSIBILITY, AUTHENTIC EXISTENCE**Paper I Western  
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Radical freedom (Sartre): since there is no essence and (atheistically) no God, we are "condemned to be free" — freedom is not a property we have but what we are; we cannot not choose (even refusing to choose is a choice).

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**2. CHOICE, RESPONSIBILITY, AUTHENTIC EXISTENCE — CONCEPTUAL LANDSCAPE****STATIC THEORY**

- Radical freedom (Sartre): since there is no essence and (atheistically) no God, we are "condemned to be free" — freedom is not a property we have but what we are; we cannot not choose (even refusing to choose is a choice).
- Total responsibility & anguish: in choosing for myself I choose an image of man as he ought to be — hence "in choosing myself I choose all men." This universal responsibility brings anguish (angoisse); abandonment (délaissement) — no God, no a priori values to lean on; despair — I can rely only on what is within my will.
- Bad faith (mauvaise foi): the self-deception of denying one's freedom — pretending one is fixed by a role, nature, or circumstance ("I am a waiter", "I couldn't help it"). Fleeing the anguish of freedom.
- Authenticity: to own one's freedom and responsibility without excuses, choosing lucidly in the face of anguish. (Kierkegaard's route to it: the leap of faith — the passionate, risk-laden commitment of the religious stage, "the knight of faith" Abraham.)
- Kierkegaard's three stages of existence: aesthetic (living for pleasure/the moment → despair/boredom) → ethical (living by universal moral duty) → religious (individual standing "before God", the leap of faith, suspension of the ethical). Movement between stages is by choice/leap, not logical deduction.

**MEMORY HOOK**

Three F's: Kierkegaard—Faith; Sartre—Freedom; Heidegger—Finitude.

**MUST-KNOW FACTS**

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2. Total responsibility & anguish: in choosing for myself I choose an image of man as he ought to be — hence "in choosing myself I choose all men." This universal responsibility brings anguish (angoisse); abandonment...
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**MAINS ANGLE**

*Reconstruct this section as a sequence of premises and consequences, then test the precise inferential bridge challenged by critics.*

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**HIGH**

## 3. BEING-IN-THE-WORLD & TEMPORALITY (Heidegger)

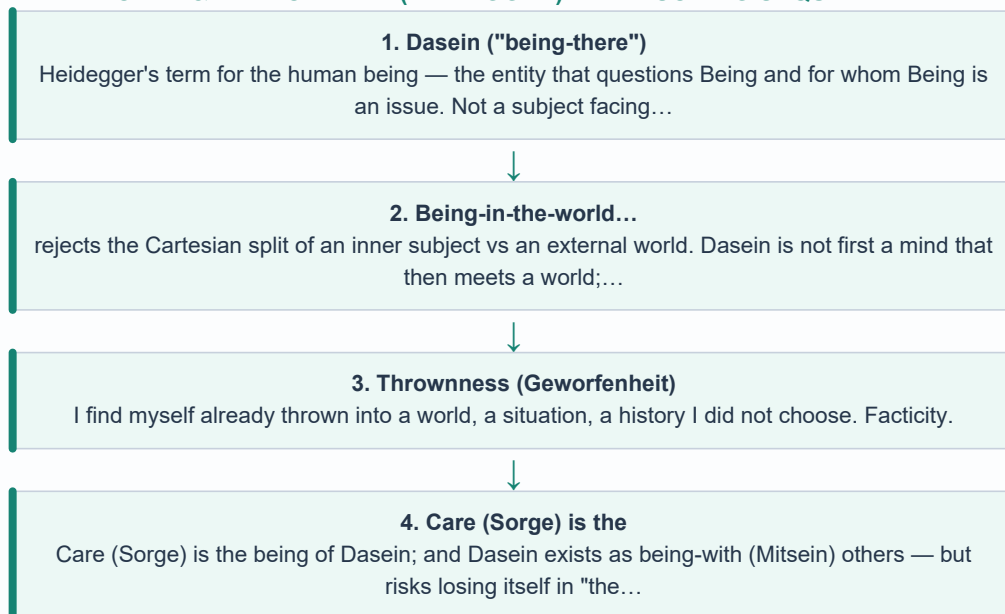
Paper I Western  
Philosophy

**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Dasein ("being-there"): Heidegger's term for the human being — the entity that questions Being and for whom Being is an issue. Not a subject facing objects, but always-already involved.

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### 3. BEING-IN-THE-WORLD & TEMPORALITY (HEIDEGGER) — REASONING SEQUENCE



#### STATIC THEORY

- Dasein ("being-there"): Heidegger's term for the human being — the entity that questions Being and for whom Being is an issue. Not a subject facing objects, but always-already involved.
- Being-in-the-world (In-der-Welt-sein): rejects the Cartesian split of an inner subject vs an external world. Dasein is not first a mind that then meets a world; it is constitutively engaged — practically absorbed, using tools ("ready-to-hand", zuhanden) before theorising ("present-at-hand", vorhanden).
- Thrownness (Geworfenheit): I find myself already thrown into a world, a situation, a history I did not choose. Facticity.
- Care (Sorge) is the being of Dasein; and Dasein exists as being-with (Mitsein) others — but risks losing itself in "the They" (das Man) — anonymous conformism, inauthenticity.
- Being-toward-death (Sein-zum-Tode): death is my ownmost, non-relational, certain possibility. Authentically facing my finitude — anticipatory resoluteness — individualises me and lets me live authentically; fleeing it (idle talk, curiosity) is inauthentic.
- Temporality (Zeitlichkeit): the meaning of the being of Dasein is time. Dasein is not in clock-time; it is temporal — stretched across having-been (past/thrownness), making-present, and coming-toward (future/projection). The future (being-toward-death, projecting possibilities) has primacy. Existence is ecstatic temporality.

#### MEMORY HOOK

Three F's: Kierkegaard—Faith; Sartre—Freedom; Heidegger—Finitude.

#### MUST-KNOW FACTS

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**MAINS ANGLE**

Reconstruct this section as a sequence of premises and consequences, then test the precise inferential bridge challenged by critics.

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**HIGH**

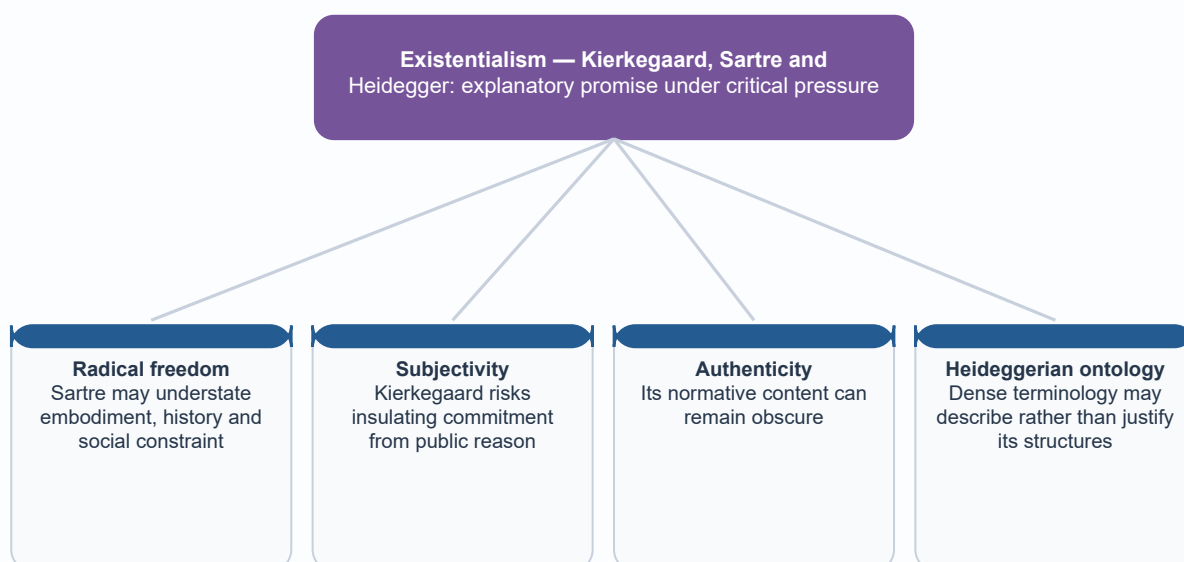
## Criticisms, Replies, Comparisons and Verified Statement Bank

Paper I Western  
Philosophy

**INTRO & ORIGIN**

A high-scoring critical answer distinguishes an external rejection from an immanent objection and gives the strongest available reply before judging the doctrine.

Statement bank retained only where the verified local topic file marks the wording as canonical; all other formulations are treated as paraphrase.

**CLAIM–OBJECTION–REPLY ARCHITECTURE****KEY DATA**

| Axis                  | Kierkegaard                | Sartre                               | Heidegger                                      |
|-----------------------|----------------------------|--------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| God                   | theistic (leap of faith)   | atheistic ("no God, no excuse")      | brackets God (ontology, not theology)          |
| Core term             | subjectivity, stages, leap | freedom, bad faith, responsibility   | Dasein, being-in-the-world, temporality        |
| Path to authenticity  | religious leap             | owning radical freedom               | anticipatory resoluteness (being-toward-death) |
| Foe                   | Hegel's system             | determinism, essentialism, bad faith | Cartesian subject-object dualism               |
| Mood disclosing truth | anxiety, despair           | anguish, nausea                      | anxiety (Angst), care                          |



## STATIC THEORY

- Key contrasts: Sartre makes freedom absolute and value self-created; Heidegger disliked being called a humanist and put Being (not the subject) first — he thought Sartre stayed trapped in the metaphysics of subjectivity. Kierkegaard alone anchors the leap in God.
- **Critical pressure:** Radical freedom — Sartre may understate embodiment, history and social constraint
- **Critical pressure:** Subjectivity — Kierkegaard risks insulating commitment from public reason
- **Critical pressure:** Authenticity — Its normative content can remain obscure
- **Critical pressure:** Heideggerian ontology — Dense terminology may describe rather than justify its structures

## MEMORY HOOK

**C-O-R-J: CLAIM → strongest OBJECTION → plausible REPLY → reasoned JUDGEMENT.**

### MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. "Existence precedes essence." — Sartre.
2. "Man is condemned to be free." — Sartre.
3. "In choosing myself I choose man." — Sartre.
4. "Truth is subjectivity." — Kierkegaard.
5. "The essence of Dasein lies in its existence." — Heidegger.
6. Being-toward-death; thrownness; the They (das Man). — Heidegger.

### UPSC TRAPS

**WRONG:** Criticism means listing hostile names.

**CORRECT:** State the objection's premise, target and consequence.

**WRONG:** A quotation can replace exposition.

**CORRECT:** Unpack the statement's technical meaning and argumentative role.

**WRONG:** Comparison is two separate summaries.

**CORRECT:** Compare axis-by-axis around a shared problem.

## COMPARATIVE ROUTES

| Core Concept    | Linked Topic           | Why It Matters                                    |
|-----------------|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Absolute system | Hegel                  | Kierkegaard protects the existing individual      |
| Intentionality  | Husserl                | Phenomenological method is transformed            |
| Cogito          | Descartes              | Embodied world-involvement replaces isolated mind |
| Faith           | Philosophy of Religion | Leap and commitment recur in reason–faith debates |

### MAINS ANGLE

*Use the statement as a compressed argument: define its terms, reconstruct what follows, stage the strongest objection and give a qualified verdict.*

### STUDY LINK

Verified knowledge file: Existentialism.md •  
 Direct local reading: Warburton, PDF pp. 284–296 and 372–407; Kenny vol. 4, PDF pp. 100–108; Cambridge Dictionary entries on Kierkegaard, Sartre and Heidegger.

HIGH

## PYQs, Applied Drills and 10/15/20-Mark Answer Architecture

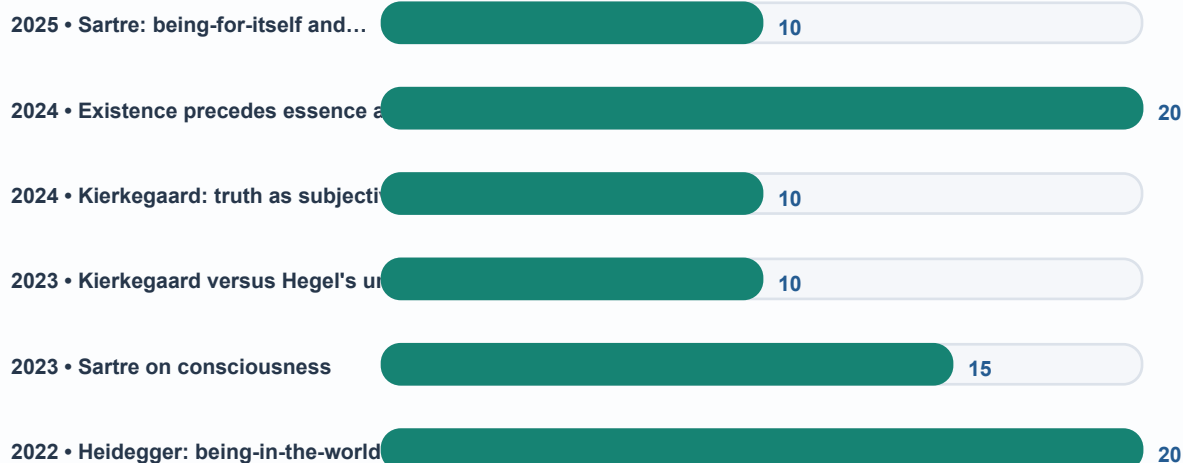
Paper I Western  
Philosophy

### INTRO & ORIGIN

The final layer converts doctrine into directive-sensitive answers. Keep exposition proportionate to marks, reserve space for criticism and end with a qualified philosophical judgement.

*PYQs reproduced from the local UPSC Western Philosophy bank for 2022–2025; wording is shortened only in the table, not altered in doctrinal demand.*

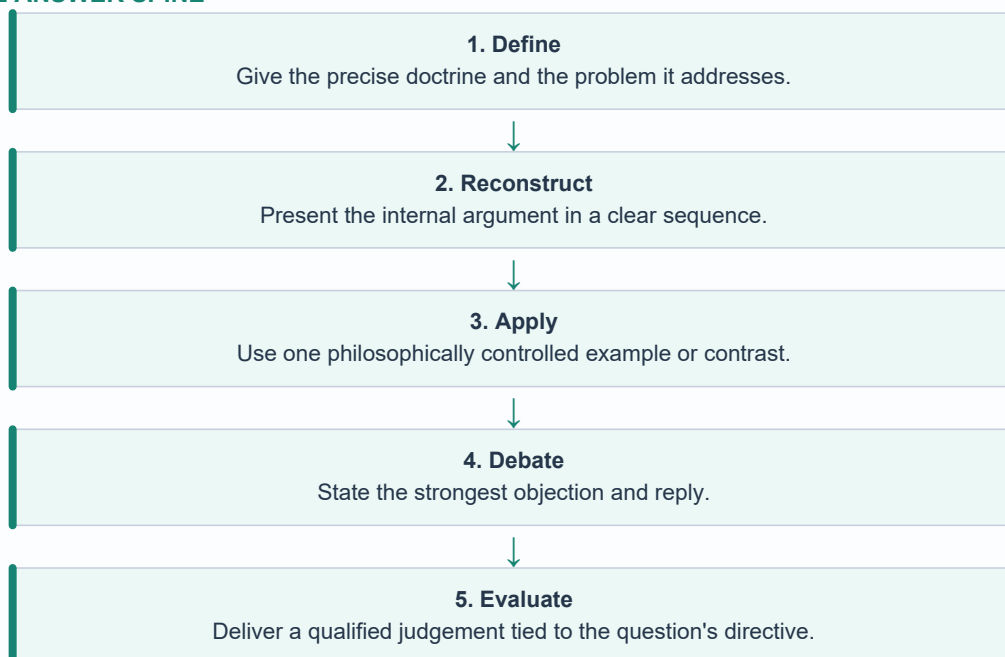
### RECENT DIRECT PYQ YIELD



*Bar length represents marks, not frequency.*

### KEY DATA

| Year | Verified Demand                                | Marks |
|------|------------------------------------------------|-------|
| 2025 | Sartre: being-for-itself and being-in-itself   | 10    |
| 2024 | Existence precedes essence and freedom         | 20    |
| 2024 | Kierkegaard: truth as subjectivity             | 10    |
| 2023 | Kierkegaard versus Hegel's universal spirit    | 10    |
| 2023 | Sartre on consciousness                        | 15    |
| 2022 | Heidegger: being-in-the-world and authenticity | 20    |
| 2022 | Kierkegaard's stages and subjectivity          | 20    |

**D-R-A-D-E ANSWER SPINE****STATIC THEORY**

- **10 marks:** 2-line context; define the key term; 3–4 linked doctrinal points; one precise objection; 2-line judgement.
- **15 marks:** establish the problem; reconstruct the argument with technical vocabulary; add comparison or example; objection–reply; balanced conclusion.
- **20 marks:** map every syllabus dimension in the question; develop the derivation; compare alternatives; stage two critical pressures; defend or qualify; conclude with an explicit criterion of success.
- [Core slogan] "Existence precedes essence.' Explain and examine with Sartre."
- [Freedom] "Man is condemned to be free.' Discuss freedom, bad faith and authenticity."
- [Heidegger] "Explain being-in-the-world and temporality in Heidegger."
- [Compare] "Compare the existentialism of Kierkegaard, Sartre and Heidegger."
- [Authenticity] "What is authentic existence? Contrast the three thinkers' routes to it."
- **7.1 — "Existence precedes essence.' Discuss." (recurring — Sartre-centred)**
  - Intro : reversal of the artisan model — no fixed human nature; man is a self-making project.
  - B1 : no God/essence → radical freedom → "condemned to be free"; choosing self = choosing man.
  - B2 : anguish, abandonment, despair; bad faith vs authenticity.
  - Link : Kierkegaard (leap of faith) & Heidegger (essence of Dasein = existence) share the primacy.
  - Assess: empowering ethics of responsibility; charge — is total freedom/valuelessness self-undermining?
  - Concl : places the concrete choosing individual at the centre of philosophy.
- **7.2 — "Explain Heidegger's being-in-the-world and temporality." (15m)**

**MEMORY HOOK**

**MARKS CONTROL DEPTH: 10 = compact argument; 15 = argument + debate; 20 = complete architecture + sustained evaluation.**

**MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. The directive determines emphasis: explain, examine, compare and evaluate are not interchangeable.
2. A 20-mark answer must show relations among subparts, not merely add more bullet points.
3. Use one stable example through exposition and criticism where possible.
4. Conclusions should identify what the doctrine successfully explains and what remains unresolved.

**UPSC TRAPS**

**WRONG:** Memorise one essay for every wording.

**CORRECT:** Adapt the same doctrine map to the directive and marks.

**WRONG:** Criticism should occupy most of the answer.

**CORRECT:** Secure accurate exposition before proportionate evaluation.

**WRONG:** A conclusion merely repeats the introduction.

**CORRECT:** It must state a defended philosophical judgement.

**MAINS ANGLE**

*For statement questions, treat the quotation as a claim needing reconstruction; for comparison, organise by axes; for 'does it solve' questions, state an explicit success criterion.*

**STUDY LINK**

Official local PYQ bank:

[\\_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2022-2025.md](#)

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End of Register Notes — UPSC Agent / Copilot CLI